CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PHYSICAL THERAPIST IN THE AI ERA

A doctorate in getting bodies moving again — part clinician, part coach, part detective.

★ **TL;DR — Around $100K median, but the runway is 4+ years: bachelor's plus a doctorate (DPT), capped by a state license. The catch is time and tuition — this is a long game with a strong finish.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

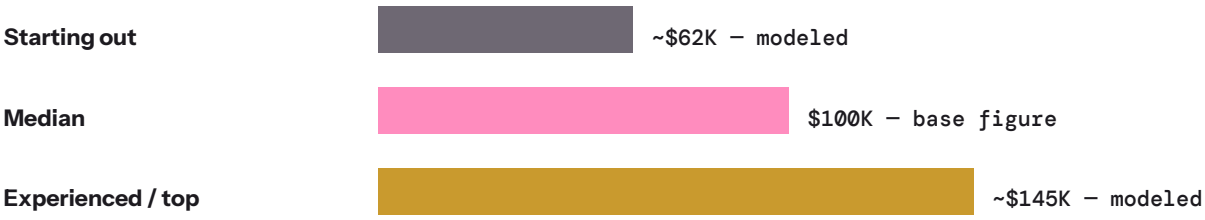
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$100K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- The payoff is real: six-figure median, deep patient relationships, and the option to own the clinic (biz flag is earned here).
- The education is the moat and the bill: a doctorate means years and debt that must be planned, not discovered.
- AI drafts notes and exercise programs, but hands-on assessment and progression decisions stay with the clinician.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Physical Therapist is a ~$100K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PHYSICAL THERAPIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Evaluate movement, strength and pain to find the actual limiting problem
- ✓ Build and progress treatment plans: exercise, manual therapy, retraining
- ✓ Coach patients through weeks of rehab — motivation is a clinical tool
- ✓ Document outcomes and coordinate with physicians and insurers

Think: a movement engineer with a coaching whistle — you diagnose the machine and train its owner.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI scribes, exercise-program generators and remote-monitoring apps are absorbing documentation and routine home-program follow-up.	Palpating, testing, watching a gait and knowing which structure is lying. Progressing a fragile post-op patient is judgment no app carries liability for.

⚠ **Do the debt math before the dream: years of doctoral tuition against a ~$100K median only works with a deliberate plan — cheap undergrad, in-state programs, no lifestyle inflation.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Patients improving visibly, week over week ✓ Settings from sports clinics to hospitals to your own practice ✓ Active work — you're on your feet, not in a chair	✗ 4+ years of school before the license ✗ Insurance paperwork and productivity quotas in many settings ✗ Physically demanding: lifting, guarding, demonstrating all day

Good fit? You love anatomy and movement, think long-term, and can finance a doctorate without drowning.
Bad fit? You need income soon or hate school — the runway is the defining feature here.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE CLASSIC ROUTE: DEGREE, THEN DPT	DOOR B — ACCELERATED 3+3 PROGRAMS
Bachelor's degree with the science prerequisites (anatomy, physiology, chemistry, physics), then a 3-year Doctor of Physical Therapy program, then the national exam and your state license. The standard, universally accepted path.	Some universities run combined bachelor's + DPT tracks that shave about a year. You commit early — as an undergrad — and must hold the GPA to stay in. Faster and cheaper when it works; less room to change your mind.

Smart move: Work as a PT aide and log observation hours in multiple settings before applying — it strengthens the application and, more importantly, tests whether you actually like the daily work.
Where you land after: Physical therapist → specialty certifications (ortho, sports, neuro), clinic director — or your own practice.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
RUN THE	BUILD THE	LOG OBSERVATION	APPLY TO	COMPLETE THE	EXAM, STATE

STEP 1 — Run the numbers and the map

FREE · TODAY

- List DPT programs, total costs and prerequisite lists; the spread is enormous.
- Read your state's PT licensing requirements so there are no surprises later.

STEP 2 — Build the undergraduate base

YEARS · THE LONG GAME

- Choose a low-cost bachelor's path with the science prerequisites built in.
- Keep the GPA high — DPT admissions are competitive.

STEP 3 — Log observation hours

DURING DEGREE

- Shadow PTs in at least two settings: outpatient, hospital, sports.
- Aide jobs in clinics double as hours and income.

STEP 4 — Apply to DPT programs

APPLICATION SEASON

- Apply broadly; weigh total debt as heavily as ranking.
- Interviews test patient sense and maturity, not just grades.

STEP 5 — Complete the doctorate

4+ YEARS TOTAL RUNWAY

- Coursework plus full-time clinical rotations across settings.
- Choose final rotations in the setting you want to be hired into.

STEP 6 — Exam, state license, first job

EXAM FEE · AFTER GRADUATION

- Pass the national PT exam (NPTE), then complete your state license application.
- New grads are hired readily — pick mentorship over a few dollars.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: map DPT programs, total costs and prerequisites; read your state license rules.
- □ Days 1–30: enroll or register for missing prerequisites; contact clinics about aide work.
- □ Days 31–60: start observation hours; build a target-school list with real debt numbers.
- □ Days 61–90: application timeline set (or prereqs underway); shadow a second setting.
- □ Day 90: the long game is structured — prereqs, hours and target programs all moving.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **MOVEMENT IS THE MEDICINE.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.